

African-American Chamber of Commerce

Executive Summary

Community Partners:

Barãta A Bey and Shawn E Hicks

Student Consulting Team:

Snehal Paliwal, Jonas Soh, Andrews Akwei

Background

About the Organization: The African American Chamber of Commerce has a mission to continuously improve business and professional opportunities for small business owners and professionals through various workshops, sponsorship opportunities, and mentorship. There are currently 2 full time employees, Barãta A. Bey, the President and Shawn E. Hicks, the Chief Operating Officer and 674 members of the organization, including 53 corporate sponsors and 14 partner organizations.

Current Technology Use and Practices: Recently, the African American Chamber of Commerce transitioned their database from an excel spreadsheet to a CRM Database named Growth Power Suite. All of their data has been placed in their CRM, and it was used to collect the name, title, company, address, phone, fax, email, website, industry, amount paid, membership date, ethnicity, gender, certifications

Project Description

Project Opportunity: The AACCWP faced challenges with how corporate RFPs were distributed and how small businesses identified and pursued relevant opportunities. Corporations often relied on limited vendor networks, resulting in inefficient applicant review processes, while small businesses lacked clear visibility into which RFPs matched their qualifications. This disconnect made procurement time-consuming and unproductive for both sides. The opportunity involved creating a centralized, data-driven platform that aligned corporate RFP requirements with qualified small business capabilities, improving efficiency, increasing small business exposure, and modernizing a largely manual process.

Project Vision: The project vision focused on improving how the AACCWP connected corporate RFPs with qualified small businesses by modernizing and optimizing its existing systems. The refined vision centered on optimizing the Chamber's existing CRM to better support members by centralizing data, automating updates, and providing targeted notifications such as certification renewals and RFP-related support. This approach aimed to streamline internal operations, improve member visibility and readiness, and establish a scalable foundation for future collaboration with corporate partners.

Project Outcomes

The project outcomes focused on delivering sustainable, practical improvements by fully leveraging the Chamber's existing CRM system. Key outcomes included automating certification renewal reminders to

help members maintain required credentials, implementing an RFP matching process that better aligns qualified small businesses with corporate opportunities, and optimizing underused CRM features to improve data accuracy and operational efficiency. Together, these outcomes reduced manual effort, improved visibility into member qualifications, and enabled more targeted engagement between the Chamber, its members, and corporate partners. The results strengthened the foundation for future RFP matching efforts while providing immediate, measurable value to both small businesses and Chamber leadership.

Project Deliverables

The project deliverables collectively documented the project's vision, scope, technical design, and long-term impact for both technical and non-technical audiences. They included stakeholder-focused user stories and use cases that defined requirements and guided scope, a finalized ERD to visualize key business entities and data relationships, and comprehensive CRM handoff documentation detailing system logic, workflows, and configurations for future technical implementation. In parallel, a CRM user guide translated these changes into accessible instructions for Chamber staff, while long-term information flow diagrams captured the client's future-state vision beyond the project's constraints. Supporting materials—including a Growth Power Suite SWOT analysis and organized client meeting decks and notes—provided strategic context, alignment rationale, and a clear record of decision-making across each project sprint.

Recommendations

Moving forward, we recommended that AACCWP continue regular collaboration with the Growth Power Suite team to better understand CRM capabilities and limitations, enabling informed decisions about future enhancements. We also suggested cleaning up and standardizing CRM tagging practices, expanding the use of reporting and analytics to evaluate member engagement and event success, and building on the current RFP matching logic through continued work with the algorithm team and a potential web-based platform. Finally, we recommended collecting consistent feedback from chamber members through surveys or forms to guide future features, refine user needs, and ensure the CRM evolves in alignment with member priorities.

Student Consulting Team

Andrews Akwei served as the sprint manager for this project and implemented the internal RFP matching pipeline. He is a third-year student majoring in Information Systems with a concentration in Cybersecurity. He will be attending summer classes this semester while working on a Supabase project.

Snehal Paliwal served as the project manager for this project and implemented the certification renewal pipeline, was the point of communication with client and Growth Power Suite team, and implemented current state improvements. She will be working at PwC as a Technology Consulting Intern in the App Modernization practice.

Jonas Soh served as the head of technology, managed and communicated the implementation details for each technological deliverable with the client and team, and prototyped an alternative solution for RFP matching using APIs. He is a third-year student majoring in Information Systems with a concentration in Data Analytics. He will be working at CyberDNA as a software engineer exploring the intersection between machine learning and cybersecurity.